

The Level tool can move and stretch the brightness levels of an image histogram with the power to adjust brightness, contrast, and tonal range by specifying the location of complete black, complete white and mid-tones in the histogram, and since every photo's histogram is unique, there is no single set of rules to guide you here. Similarly, Photoshop's Curves tools are perhaps one of the most powerful and flexible image transformation effects, and since photographers effectively paint with light, curves are central to their practice because they affect light's two primary influences: tones and contrasts. Tonal curves are essentially what gives different film types their unique character, so understanding how they work allows you to mimic any film without ever having to retake the actual photograph. You should however always keep a tight hand while applying these tools, as anything that stretches the image histogram increases the possibility of posterization.

Rotate or crop your clicks

Finally now you'll have an image with most alterations done and taken care of, and the most important part left now is the correct framing of your shot, requiring rotation or cropping of the original image. A vast majority of shots can be dramatically enhanced simply by cropping them to strengthen their composition. No definite principles guide this step and it's all about your personal vision of the photo, but a pretty well known and powerful compositional technique is the rule of thirds (covered already in the section *Developing an Eye for Photography*). You don't need to worry about perfectly aligning everything with the thirds of the image but consider it as a rough, tried and tested guideline, and what's usually more important is that your main subject or region isn't always in the absolute center of the picture. This doesn't mean symmetry isn't ever beneficial, just that the specialty and uniqueness of the subject should be portrayed best. All editing software have fairly easy to apply cropping tools that allow you to simply move your cursor across the edge points to carve out the portion you need. You may also want to crop your image so that it exactly matches a given print size, then the aspect ratio of your crop can often be specified within your photo editing software making the process much easier.

Now you have a pretty decent idea how your shot has emerged but there is still scope for further refinements like colors and enhancements which is really a catch-all category that you can go wild with! Altering the colors in your image means playing around with the saturation, vibrance or other